

STL: Leading ESG efforts from the front

What are STL's fundamental ESG drivers? Please highlight some ESG achievements.

Our approach to ESG is proactive and an essential enabler across our value chain, both within and beyond institutional boundaries. We believe that risk to business operations can be mitigated only by addressing environmental, social, and governance issues. Our efforts are, therefore, driven not just by national priorities, but also by global goals. In a physically diverse and climatically demanding region, our low-carbon strategy has preserved shareholder interests while simultaneously delivering a healing touch to the subcontinent's teeming millions.

These include comprehensive environmental stewardship converging verticals like climate action, water positivity, building circular economies, and greener business operations. On the social front, STL is dedicated to creating a workplace that is equitable, safe, and respectful of universal human rights and fair labour practises. We focus on issues such as women's empowerment, access to quality healthcare and education, and the development of climate-resilient communities. On the governance front, board-level committees and policies ensure we adhere to responsible, transparent business practices, best-in-class processes and necessary grievance redressal mechanisms.

change, leverage tech to bridge the digital divide, are agile to operate irrespective of socio-ecological disruptions and are sustainable.

What sustainability challenges does STL face, and how are you overcoming those challenges?

STL has set aggressive ESG goals for 2025 and 2030, with the goal of ensuring the global sustainability of its operations while also promoting a more inclusive future. Continuing to pursue such high sustainability goals might provide a few challenges for any company.

With our operations located in areas that come under Marathwada – a drought-prone region, India's water scarcity is a challenge for the sustainability of STL's business interests in the long term. Also, the COVID-19 pandemic resulted in unprecedented odds not only for the business, but also for our social transformation initiatives, stretching our on-ground infrastructure to its limits. We had to come to terms with the realities of the New Normal, molding our corporate culture and workflows accordingly to meet its demands.

However, STL's response to such challenges has always been driven by technical innovation, cross-sector collaboration, and policy leadership. Energy efficiency efforts, creative use of technology, process innovation, and industry linkages have helped us in the precise management of emissions, water and waste minimization, and building a greener supply chain. For our social efforts, we leveraged tech and partnerships to design programs that have not only ensured anytime, anywhere access to quality healthcare, but also make quality digital education accessible to the masses and are building water-resilient villages.

Supporting India's green growth is a shared priority. What is STL's contribution to the same?

Several of our ESG Goals for 2025 and 2030 are aligned with the aspirations of green growth. But we believe that achieving net-zero, optimal use of energy is also essential. Therefore, we use proven technology such as variable frequency motors, motion sensors, advanced effluent treatment, and monitoring systems, demonstrating the viability of economic growth through environmentally friendly operations. Over **14,000 tCO2 emissions** and significant energy costs have been avoided through such initiatives

A portrait of Akanksha Sharma, Global ESG Head at STL. She is a woman with long dark hair, wearing a black blazer over a black and white checkered dress. She is standing with her hands clasped in front of her.

Akanksha tells how STL is creating a greener, more digitally inclusive world by building sustainable digital networks for the future.

■ Akanksha Sharma
Global ESG Head, STL

We are actively working to ensure that we can meet the targets we've set for 2025 and 2030. Within our operations, we've diverted 97% of our waste from landfills in FY22. All our Indian manufacturing units have been **Zero Liquid Discharge certified** and over **2.72 lakh cubic meters of water** has been recycled. In 2020, STL became the world's first integrated optic fibre and cables manufacturer to be **Zero Waste to Landfill certified**. We've extended this to our Italy plants as well. We've reinforced these efforts by replenishing **1.4+** cubic meters of water in communities and undertaking **1.79 lakh** plantations in communities. Over **1,000** villages have been covered and **1.47+** lives transformed through our social impact programs. Through collective action with state governments, district authorities, NGOs and community involvement, we've been able to ensure our community interventions drive holistic